

Title PL Russia-Aligned Operation Overload Renews Targeting Polish Elections

16/05/2025

Summary

- Between 12-14 May, 6 Operation Overload posts claiming a terrorist threat by Ukrainian militants on Poland's election day. Content impersonating European law enforcement agencies was shared on X and BlueSky.
- The meta-narrative was that Polish government is unable to guarantee election security; sub-narratives portrayed Ukrainian refugees as a security threat to Poland, claimed that Ukrainian militants operate in Europe, and that Ukrainian terror attack plans are being covered up.
- 6 posts garnered more than 548,000 views - however, consistent with previous Operation Overload activity, shares and likes were largely inorganic and driven by a coordinated network of accounts.
- Techniques used included impersonation, deceptively edited content, and bot amplification.
- Platforms should remove the coordinated networks involved in the amplification of the operation. Media, law enforcement and other organisations should be made aware that they have been targeted by the campaign.

Incident

Between 12-14 May, Operation Overload published at least 6 pieces of content continuing to target Poland's presidential elections. The activity described here is similar to those covered in a previous Incident Alert (0061). Five of these posts surfaced on X on 12 May, and a further one on 14 May. The 5 posts published on 12 May were also cross posted to BlueSky.

All posts suggest a terrorist threat targeting the first round of voting on 18 May and appear aimed to suppress voter participation. 5 of these posts attribute the security threat to Ukrainian militants operating in Europe (see e.g. [here](#) and [here](#)); the remaining post links the threat to claims of a planned terror attack on Hungarian Prime Minister Orban (see e.g. [here](#)). Videos featured British and French law enforcement officers and used an AI-generated extension of their voices to warn of a terrorist threat posed by alleged Ukrainian militants in Europe. The videos also contained the logos of various law enforcement agencies. Some posts were attributed to large European media organisations like the BBC, France24, Der Spiegel and LesEchos. At the time of writing (14 May), two of the accounts posting on BlueSky had been removed.

Operation Overload posted a further 6 videos not focused on the Polish election between 8-12 May; these alleged that Ukrainian 'militants' were plotting assassinations of senior politicians in other European countries, such as [Germany](#), [Slovakia](#) and [Romania](#). Posts were only published in English.

Narrative

Meta narrative: EU countries and their security services are unable to ensure election security.

Sub-narratives: There is a serious terrorist threat to the presidential elections in Poland; the Polish government is unable to guarantee the security of elections; Ukrainian refugees are a security threat to EU countries; there is widespread censorship of Ukrainian terror attack plans in Europe.

Impact

Reach: As of 14 May, the six posts on X garnered a combined total of over 549,400 views and 4,932 engagements (likes and shares). Only 1 of 3 BlueSky cross-posts had any engagement (1 like). Consistent with past activity, this engagement was inorganic; all X posts had a very similar number of likes (between 500 and 600 each) and shares (between 260 and 280 each). Two of six posts were reposted within a 90-second interval, and the remaining ones within 2.5 hours of each other. Accounts that reposted this content exhibited clear signs of inauthenticity.

Outcome: The impact is limited because the content appears largely confined to Operation Overload's existing network of amplifiers and has not achieved widespread organic traction.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [T0135: Undermine](#): Undermine trust in Polish government and law enforcement institutions by portraying them as unable to guarantee election security; polarise Polish society by promoting negative sentiment towards Ukrainian refugees.

Objective: [T0139.001: Discourage](#): Discourage citizens from participating in presidential elections by stoking fears of a terrorist threat.

[T0143.003: Impersonated Persona](#): Impersonating legitimate media outlets and personalities to increase

legitimacy.

[T0023.001: Reframe Context](#): Use existing content, alter it and add false claims.

[T0086.003: Deceptively Edit Images \(Cheap Fakes\)](#): Altered front page of a prominent media with a false headline to deceive audiences.

[T0049.003: Bots Amplify via Automated Forwarding and Reposting](#): A coordinated inorganic network of amplifiers on X was driving engagement.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Action taken: Continued monitoring of Operation Overload activity targeting Polish elections.

Recommendations: Insist on platforms taking down false content and coordinated networks involved in its amplification; Raise awareness with media and other organisations targeted by the campaign.

Report	Threat Actor	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
N/A	Russia	Upon request	Lukasz Janulewicz, Olga Tokariuk, ISD	X, Bluesky	